FAMILY CAREGIVING

Safety squad: getting grandkids involved in keeping a grandparent's home safe

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If you are caring for an aging parent while raising kids, you already know how thin the day can get. Here is some good news: your children can help, and home safety is one of the best places for them to start. The jobs are concrete, the kids can see the results, and grandparents usually love the company.

Kids gain something too. They learn responsibility, practical skills and a real understanding of what aging looks like. And they get time with their grandparents that is about doing something together, not just visiting.

Hazard hunt (ages 5 and up)

Turn it into a game. Give younger kids a short list and let them walk the house looking for:

- Throw rugs that slide or curl at the edges
- Cords crossing walkways
- Shoes, magazines or pet toys on the floor
- Burned-out bulbs and dark hallways

They report what they find, and an adult decides what to fix. Kids are often better at spotting floor clutter than adults because they are closer to it.

Night light patrol (ages 7 and up)

Many falls happen on the way to the bathroom at night. Kids can check that night lights work along the path from the bed to the bathroom and help plug in new ones where the path goes dark. Motion-activated lights are even better, and setting them up is a satisfying project. Our article on preventing falls at night explains why this route matters so much.

Tech helpers (ages 10 and up)

Grandkids are often the household experts on phones and smart devices. They can help:

- Set up a smart speaker so a grandparent can call family or turn on lights by voice
- Save emergency and family numbers as favorites
- Teach a grandparent to answer a video call or check a video doorbell before opening the door
- Set medication or appointment reminders, with an adult confirming the details

Patience is the skill here. Encourage kids to show, then let the grandparent try, rather than doing it for them.

Reach and storage crew (ages 10 and up)

Items stored up high are a common reason older adults climb on step stools. Kids can help move everyday things like dishes, snacks and cleaning supplies down to between hip and shoulder height. It is simple, fast and removes a real risk.

Storm prep team (teens)

Hurricane season is part of life in Tampa Bay. Teens can help check flashlights and batteries, test a weather radio, refresh the water supply and make sure a written list of medications and medical equipment is easy to find. If a grandparent depends on oxygen or other powered equipment, that list matters most. See our guide to hurricane plans for power wheelchairs and oxygen.

Eyes and ears (all ages)

Grandkids notice things. Ask them to tell you if a grandparent seems unsteady, holds onto furniture to walk or has stopped using part of the house. Those small changes are often the first sign that the home no longer fits.

What to leave to adults

Kids should not help a grandparent stand, walk, transfer or get in and out of the tub. Those tasks need training and the right technique. Keep kids' jobs focused on the environment, technology and company.

When the home needs more than a helping hand

If the hazard hunt turns up more than your family can handle, or a grandparent is starting to struggle, a professional assessment can help. A Home Safety Visit sends a licensed physical therapist to see how your loved one moves through the home, and gives your family a photo report and a prioritized hazard list. We visit homes in Hillsborough, Manatee and Pinellas counties, and offer virtual visits in Florida, Ohio and New York. Every service starts with an Initial Consultation, a 30-minute phone call. Current prices are on our pricing page.

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